Mei Zhou

家常菜

Mei's Chinese Home Kitchen

Traditional recipes, cooked the light way



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Fifty-one recipes · First edition

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A Letter Before We Begin

When I was small, my grandmother's kitchen had one window, one wok and a clay pot that was always on the stove. In winter it held soup with ginger and a few red dates. In summer it held mung beans, cooking slowly until they split open. Nobody in our family called this medicine. It was simply how you fed people, and how you looked after them without making a fuss.

I didn't understand how much she knew until I moved away and tried to cook for myself. My first stir-fries swam in oil. My dumplings burst. My fish came out tough and smelled too strongly of fish. I called home a great deal in those years.

What I learned, slowly, is that Chinese home cooking is not complicated. It rests on a handful of habits: cut everything before you light the stove, use ginger and scallion with fish and meat, steam and simmer more often than you fry, and choose food for the weather and for the person who will eat it. Once you have those habits, everything else is variation.

This book is a collection of those habits, written out as recipes. These are the dishes I cook every week, and many of them you may already know from my videos. Here they have exact amounts, the small steps I sometimes skip on camera, and the reasons behind them.

You will not find restaurant dishes here, glossy with oil and sugar. You will find the food Chinese families actually eat at home: soups before the meal, a steamed dish, one or two quick stir-fries, a plate of greens and a bowl of rice. It is lighter than takeout and, I think, a good deal more satisfying.

Everything has been tested with ingredients from a regular American supermarket. Where a trip to an Asian grocery is worth it, I say so, and I always give you a swap.

Cook slowly at first. Taste as you go. And when something turns out well, make it again the next week, the way my grandmother did, until you no longer need the page.

Mei

How to Use This Book

The recipes

Every recipe begins with a short note, then a list of what you will need on the left and the method on the right. Read the whole recipe once before you start. Chinese cooking moves fast once the pan is hot, so have everything cut, measured and within reach before you turn on the heat. My grandmother called this getting the board ready, and it matters more than any other step.

Quantities are given in American cups and spoons, with metric weights alongside. Where I write *1 tablespoon*, I mean a level measuring spoon. Salt is Diamond Crystal kosher salt unless I say otherwise; if you use fine table salt, use about half as much.

The thermal nature of food

Above each recipe you will see a small red note such as **温 Warm** or **凉 Cool**. In traditional Chinese food culture, every ingredient has a thermal nature, a sense of whether it warms the body or cools it. There are five steps on the scale:

	Nature	What it means at the table
寒	Cold	Strongly cooling. Watermelon, crab, seaweed. Best in hot weather and in small amounts.
凉	Cool	Gently cooling. Cucumber, tofu, pears, most leafy greens.
平	Neutral	Balanced, suitable for everyone, every day. Rice, corn, pork, eggs, carrots.
温	Warm	Gently warming. Ginger, chicken, scallions, red dates. Good on cold days.
热	Hot	Strongly warming. Chili, cinnamon, lamb, black pepper. Use with a light hand.

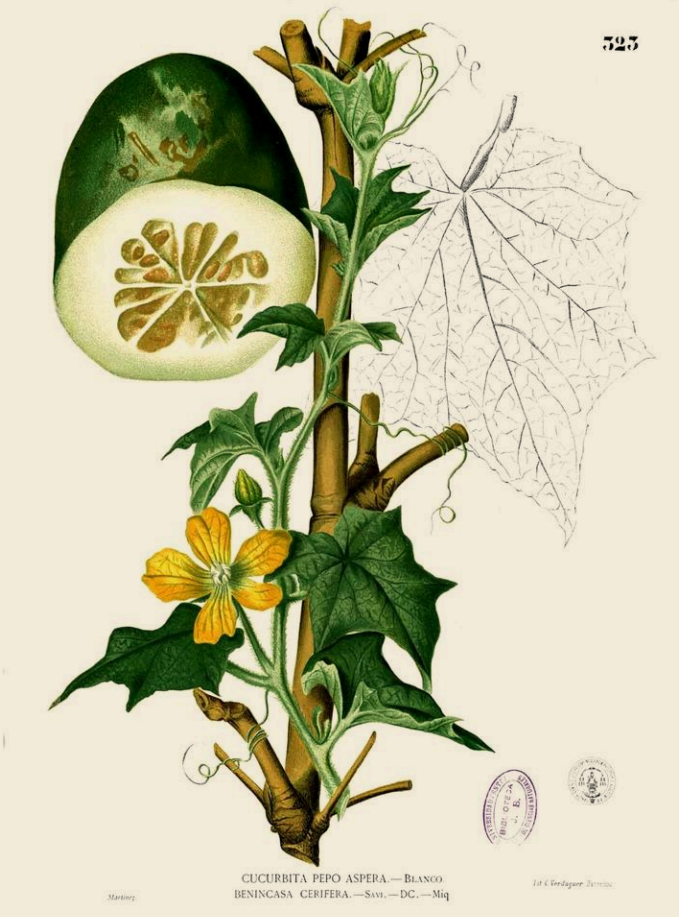
The label on each recipe describes the dish as a whole, as it is usually understood in Chinese homes. You don't need to follow it to enjoy the food. But if you notice that you feel sluggish and chilly in winter, you might lean toward the warm dishes; if you run hot in summer, the cool ones will feel right. My companion book, *Eat for the Season*, explains this way of eating in much more detail.

Chapter One

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Soups

Quick soups for weeknights, slow soups for Sundays



Winter melon, Benincasa hispida. From Francisco Manuel Blanco, Flora de Filipinas, Manila, 1880–1883.



Gentle Chicken and Corn Soup 鸡蓉玉米羹

鸡蓉玉米羹 *jī róng yù mǐ gēng*

Gentle Chicken and Corn Soup

Serves 4 · 25 minutes · 平 Neutral

This was the first soup I made for my own family, and it is still the one friends ask for when they are tired or getting over a cold. Every Chinese restaurant in America serves a version, usually thickened until it is closer to glue. At home it should be light and silky, with soft ribbons of egg and only enough body to coat the spoon.

Chopping the chicken very finely and loosening it with water is what makes it melt into the soup instead of forming chewy lumps.

You will need

- 1 boneless, skinless chicken breast (about 8 oz / 225 g)
- 1 teaspoon cornstarch
- 1 tablespoon Shaoxing wine
- 4 cups (1 liter) low-sodium chicken stock
- 2 thin slices ginger
- 1 can (14.75 oz / 418 g) cream-style corn
- 1 cup (150 g) frozen corn kernels
- 3 tablespoons cornstarch mixed with 3 tablespoons water
- 2 eggs, lightly beaten
- ½ teaspoon salt, or to taste
- ¼ teaspoon ground white pepper
- ½ teaspoon toasted sesame oil
- 1 scallion, thinly sliced

1. Cut the chicken into small pieces, then chop it with a cleaver or pulse it in a food processor until it looks like coarse ground meat. Put it in a bowl with the 1 teaspoon cornstarch, the Shaoxing wine, a pinch of salt and 3 tablespoons of cold water. Stir with chopsticks until smooth and loose, almost like a thick batter.

2. Bring the stock and ginger to a boil in a medium pot. Add the creamed corn and the corn kernels, return to a simmer and cook for 5 minutes. Lift out the ginger.

3. Stir a ladle of the hot soup into the chicken to loosen it further. Pour the chicken into the pot in a thin stream, stirring all the time with chopsticks so it separates into fine shreds. Simmer for 2 minutes, until every piece has turned white.

4. Stir the cornstarch mixture again and pour it in, stirring, until the soup thickens slightly and turns glossy, about 1 minute.

5. Turn the heat to its lowest setting. Hold the bowl of beaten egg high above the pot and pour it in a very thin stream while you stir the soup slowly in one direction. Stop stirring and wait 10 seconds before giving one last gentle stir. This is how you get soft ribbons instead of scrambled bits.

6. Season with the salt, white pepper and sesame oil. Ladle into bowls and scatter with scallion.

Mei's note. *When the stomach is tired and the appetite small, this is the soup I make. Corn is neutral and gentle on digestion, and the chicken warms lightly. For a vegetarian version, use vegetable stock and replace the chicken with half a block of silken tofu, cut into small cubes.*



Juicy Garlic Shrimp, the Velvet Way 蒜香虾仁

蒜香虾仁 *suàn xiāng xiā rén*

Juicy Garlic Shrimp, the Velvet Way

Serves 2 as part of a meal · 15 minutes, plus 10 minutes resting · 温 Warm

This is the recipe from my garlic-shrimp video, which more people have asked me to write down than any other. The shrimp are rubbed with a little salt and baking soda, rinsed, then coated in cornstarch and left to rest. When they hit the pan they turn plump and snappy, exactly like the shrimp in a good Cantonese restaurant, and they need only a spoonful of oil.

You will need

- 10 oz (300 g) raw shrimp, peeled and deveined
- ¼ teaspoon baking soda
- ¼ teaspoon salt, plus a pinch
- 1 teaspoon cornstarch mixed with 1 tablespoon water
- 1 tablespoon neutral oil
- 6 cloves garlic, minced
- 2 slices ginger, finely shredded
- 1 scallion, white and green parts sliced separately
- 1 tablespoon Shaoxing wine
- ½ teaspoon light soy sauce
- ¼ teaspoon sugar
- A pinch of ground white pepper

1. Put the shrimp in a bowl with the baking soda and a pinch of salt. Rub them gently for a minute, then rinse well under cold water and pat completely dry with paper towels.

2. Toss the shrimp with the ¼ teaspoon salt and the cornstarch mixture. Leave them in the refrigerator for 10 minutes. They will feel slightly firm and sticky.

3. Heat a wok or skillet over high heat. Add the oil and lay the shrimp in a single layer. Leave them for 30 seconds without moving, then turn them and cook for 30 seconds more, until they are just pink. Push them to the side of the pan.

4. Add the garlic, ginger and scallion whites to the cleared space and stir for 20 seconds until fragrant but not browned.

5. Pour the Shaoxing wine around the edge of the pan so it sizzles. Add the soy sauce, sugar and white pepper and toss everything together for 30 seconds. Scatter with scallion greens and serve at once.

Mei's note. *Drying the shrimp well is the step people skip. Wet shrimp steam in the pan and turn rubbery. If your shrimp are large, cut them in half lengthwise so they cook in the same time.*



Crispy Potstickers with a Lace Skirt 冰花煎饺

冰花煎饺 *bīng huā jiān jiǎo*

Crispy Potstickers with a Lace Skirt

Serves 2 to 3 · 15 minutes, with dumplings already made · 平 Neutral

The trick from my potsticker video. The dumplings are browned in a little oil, then steamed in a thin batter of flour and water. As the water evaporates, the batter turns into a crisp, golden lace that joins all the dumplings together. You turn the whole thing out onto a plate upside down. It looks like something from a restaurant and uses only a tablespoon of oil.

You will need

- 15 to 18 uncooked dumplings, fresh or frozen
- 1 tablespoon neutral oil
- 1 tablespoon all-purpose flour
- ½ teaspoon cornstarch
- ⅔ cup (160 ml) water
- A few drops toasted sesame oil
- 1 scallion, thinly sliced, and toasted sesame seeds

1. Mix the flour, cornstarch and water in a cup until smooth.

2. Heat a 10-inch nonstick skillet with a lid over medium heat. Add the oil and swirl to coat. Arrange the dumplings in the pan in a circle, flat side down, close together but not quite touching.

3. Fry for 2 minutes, until the bottoms are light golden.

4. Stir the batter and pour it into the pan around the dumplings. It will spit, so cover with the lid at once. Turn the heat to medium-high and steam for 6 minutes (8 minutes if the dumplings were frozen).

5. Remove the lid. Lower the heat to medium and cook for 2 to 3 minutes more, until all the water has evaporated and the batter has turned into a thin, crisp, golden lace. Drizzle a few drops of sesame oil around the edge.

6. Loosen the edges with a spatula. Put a plate upside down over the pan and, holding both together firmly, flip them over. Scatter with scallion and sesame seeds and serve with dipping sauce.

Mei's note. *A nonstick pan really helps here. If the lace is pale, keep cooking; it needs time to dry and brown after the water has gone.*
